

MANMOHAN SINGH



• Prime Minister

AGENDA When you return to power for a second term, the burden of expectation doubles too. The prime minister's agenda took its cue from the Congress manifesto and included a Food Security Act that promised food for all and the Women's Reservations Bill as well as reservations at the urban and local level, and modernisation at the Panchayat level. Manmohan's personal touch could be seen in the number of mechanisms to monitor governance such as a Delivery Monitoring Unit in the PMO for the flagship schemes, five annual reports on key ministries and Bharat Nirman quarterly reports from all. Free of the Left, he hoped to go ahead with his disinvestment plans too.

• PERFORMANCE

Politics plays a major role in the implementation of Manmohan's agenda. Consensus eludes the Women Reservations and Land Acquisition Amendment bills. The disinvestment plans hit a political roadblock with Mamata Banerjee but the good news is that a National Health Regulator is on the drawing board and the Bill for a National Council for Higher Education is ready to be presented in the Winter Session. The Delivery Monitoring Unit has been set up in the PMO and a draft note on the Independent Evaluation Office in the Planning Commission is ready. The Cabinet has okayed 50 per cent reservation for women in Panchayats. But events like the Sharm el-Sheikh fiasco have cast a shadow on Manmohan's legacy.

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